

Kettlebell Guide

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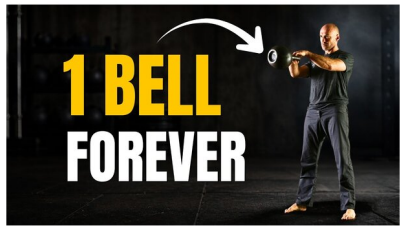
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The Pavel Tsatsouline method

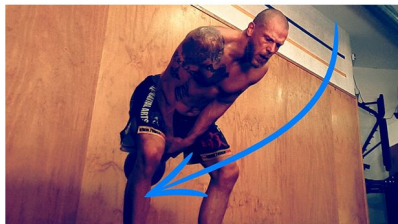
Pavel Tsatsouline carried the kettlebell out of Soviet military and girevoy circles, sold it first to American special forces and then to everybody else, and founded StrongFirst. His picks open this guide because they are the shortest useful answer to what a kettlebell is for: three exercises, or five if you want a whole program in twenty minutes.

Pavel Tsatsouline	The big three (click)	The 20 minute plan (click)
		

His big three

All three start at [the hinge](#), and he will not let anyone past it: hips back, spine neutral, the way you shut a car door with your backside when both hands are full of groceries.

Exercise	How it goes	Why he picks it	Watch for
Overspeed eccentric swing	Snap the hips, then throw the bell back down between the legs as hard as you can instead of waiting for gravity to bring it home.	Force plate work he cites has a spiked 53 lb bell landing like 500 lb, so the tendons take loading you could never safely hold, and only for a fraction of a second.	An advanced swing. Earn it in order: hinge, sumo deadlift, ordinary swing, then this.
One-legged deadlift	Stand on one leg, bell in the opposite hand, hinge forward, stand back up.	Tactical teams who kept tearing hamstrings stopped once it went into the training. The big movers were strong, the stabilizers around hip, knee and ankle were asleep.	The load is not the point. Past fifty this is the fall-prevention lift.
Snatch	Ground to overhead in one movement, fast enough that the bell flies up rather than gets lifted.	Speed first, then conditioning he describes as sprinting without running, then a thoracic spine that stays open instead of hunching forward.	A less democratic exercise, in his words. Like the parallel bar dip, you either have the shoulder for it or you wait.

Overspeed: attack the floor	One-legged deadlift	Snatch lockout
		

The what the hell effect is his name for what happens next. Train mostly swings for a few months and the golf drive goes thirty yards further, or you clear a fence at sixty without planning it first. Everyone asks the same question, which is what the hell happened, I only did swings. His answer is unglamorous. The swing trains power and the hinge pattern at once, and nearly everything athletic runs on that pattern.

The twenty minute plan after fifty

Five exercises, one bell, three mornings a week. Start at 8 to 12 kg, which is 18 to 26 lb, and lighter if you are coming back from an injury. Reaching for the big bell to prove a point is the usual way this ends in a month off. Warm up for two or three minutes first: leg swings, arm circles, a few bodyweight squats.

#	Exercise	Reps	The cue that matters
1	Sumo deadlift	8 to 10	Sit back, do not squat down
2	Towel swing	10 to 15	Slack towel means your arms took over
3	Halo	5 each way	Glutes tight, circles get tighter
4	Row	8 to 10 per side	Pull from the armpit
5	Seated floor press	8 to 10 per side	Nothing to arch against

Sumo deadlift	Towel swing	Halo	Row	Seated press
				

Click any tile above for that exercise's tutorial.

The towel is the clever part. Loop it through the handle, hold both ends, and your arms can no longer cheat: the moment the shoulders start muscling the bell up, the towel goes slack and tells on you. His one safety rule stands on its own. Never contest the space with a kettlebell. If it starts pulling forward, let go of it.

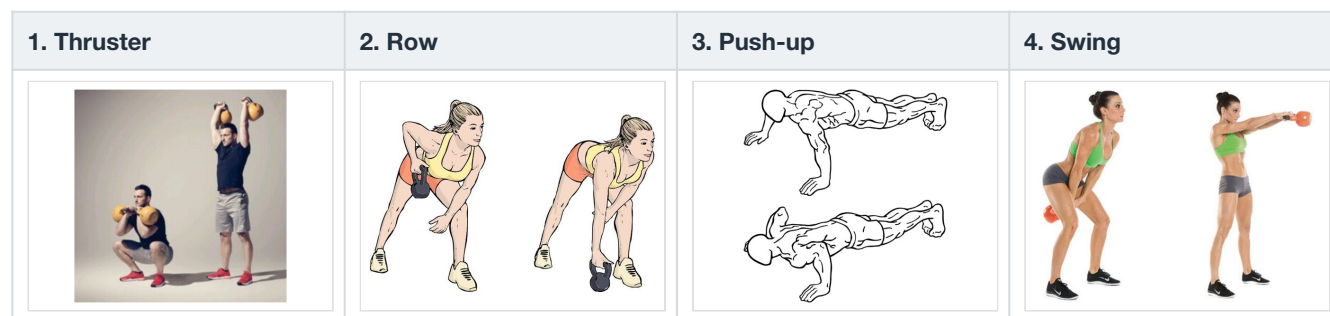
The circuit. All five back to back, 15 to 30 seconds between exercises, then 60 to 90 seconds at the end. Two rounds. Monday, Wednesday and Friday with a rest day in between, because after fifty it is recovery rather than effort that limits progress. When it gets easy, add time under load instead of weight: pause two seconds at the bottom of the deadlift, lower the row on a slow three count, hold the press locked out for a second.

1 Kettlebell, 4 Moves, 3x per week

This one is called the Core Four, from coach James of What Pertains to James. One bell, four moves, 10 reps of each done back to back. That is one round. Repeat until the session is over. It is the workout he gives all his clients, and the whole program fits on an index card.

Video: 1 Kettlebell, 4 Moves, 3x per week, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=urXeFl7ZDP8>

Move, 10 reps each	What it works	Notes
1. Thruster	Quads, shoulders, triceps, upper chest, with the core braced the whole time	The hardest of the four, so it goes first
2. Row	Back, biceps, forearms	Five per side. Pull-ups work instead
3. Push-up	Chest, shoulders, triceps	Plain push-ups here, though kettlebell push-ups are his favorite for chest strength
4. Swing	The posterior chain, as a ballistic finisher	Deadlifts or snatches can stand in



Programming. Three sessions a week, 30 minutes each, which he calls his 3 by 30 system. Rest between rounds as long as you need. That usually works out to five to eight rounds. In the video he uses a 24 kg bell, 53 lb, and most days gets through seven or eight.

Why it works. The four moves cover the main patterns of the body. Thrusters and push-ups are the lower and upper push, swings and rows the lower and upper pull. With a heavy enough bell it builds real muscle, the legs especially. It also doubles as cardio. His answer to people who ask what he does for cardio is to ask whether they are doing the workout.

Adjusting it. If your chest is sore, drop the push-ups for a session. Sore hamstrings, drop the swings. As you get stronger, add reps to one move rather than to all of them, swings being the usual candidate. His advice to beginners is to change nothing for the first few months and just show up three times a week.

Technique for the [thruster](#), the [row](#) and the [swing](#) is covered later in this guide.

Nineteen Kettlebell Exercises Ranked

How the ranking works

Nineteen kettlebell exercises, sorted S down to E. The sort is by return on the time you put in. An S lift earns a permanent place in the week because it trains something large and trains it hard. An E lift is not dangerous or useless. It just does not pay for the minutes it costs when better options exist.

Three things push a lift up the list: how much muscle it recruits, how much load it can carry once the technique is there, and whether it teaches something the other lifts do not. Grinds like the press and the squat load heavy. Ballistics like the snatch and the jerk build power and drive the heart rate. Between those two families you have most of what a kettlebell is good for.

Three things push a lift down: a small muscle group, a hard ceiling on load, or a long time cost per useful rep. The Turkish get-up is the clearest example. Nothing is wrong with it. One rep just takes thirty seconds and trains less per minute than a set of swings, so it lands at the bottom of a list sorted this way. Plenty of good coaches rank it near the top for shoulder health and movement quality. If that is what you want from it, move it up and ignore this ranking.

This is a reference document, not medical advice. Ballistic lifts with a heavy iron ball are unforgiving of a sloppy back or a loose grip. If something hurts, stop, and get a coach to watch you before you add weight.

The ranking at a glance

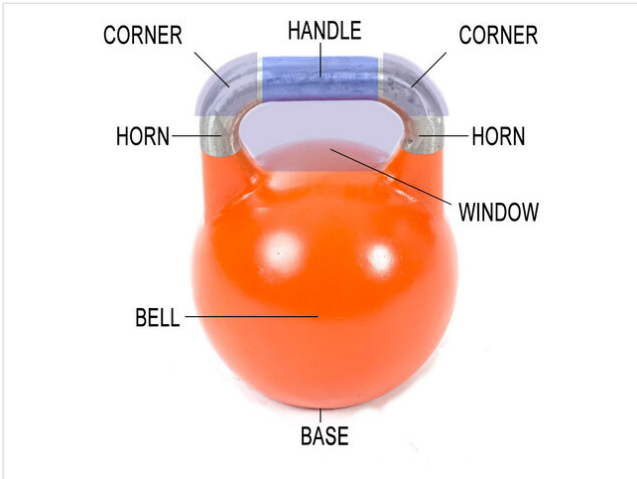
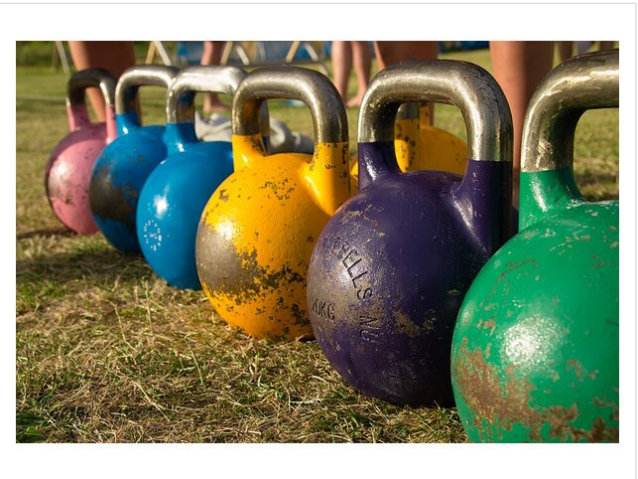
Tier	Exercise	What it mainly buys you
S	Goblet squat	Legs, deep squat position, easy to load and easy to learn
S	Press	Overhead strength, the single best kettlebell grind
S	Full snatch	Whole body power, top conditioning lift
S	Clean and jerk (long cycle)	The most total work per minute of anything here
S	Jerk	Leg drive and overhead lockout under real load
S	Pendulum swing	Efficient hinge, the base under every sport lift
A	Clean	The gateway to every racked and overhead lift
A	Hardstyle swing	Glutes and hamstrings, hard, in very little time
A	Half snatch	Snatch power with a friendlier hand and grip cost
A	Deadlift	Safe first hinge, teaches the pattern under load
B	Lunge	Single leg strength and hip stability
B	Row	Upper back pulling, the balance to all the pressing
C	Suitcase carry	Grip and anti-side-bend core
C	Thruster	Squat plus press in one gasping package
D	Windmill	Hip and thoracic mobility with a load overhead
E	Bench press	Chest and triceps, but a barbell does it better
E	Around the world	Warm-up, coordination, light core
E	Atlas swing	Rotational core and shoulder control
E	Turkish get-up	Shoulder stability and ground-to-stand skill

Things every lift depends on

Learn these five once and the rest of the guide gets much shorter.

The bell itself

A kettlebell has a handle, two corners where the handle bends down into the horns, a window your hand passes through, a bell, and a flat base. The vocabulary matters because the coaching cues use it. "Hand in the corner" and "insert through the window" are instructions, not poetry.

Anatomy	Competition bells
	

Cast iron bells grow as they get heavier. Competition bells are all the same size no matter the weight, which is why kettlebell sport lifters use them. If you plan to do long sets of jerks or snatches, the steel competition bell is worth the money. For everything else, cast iron is fine.

Starting weights that work for most people: 16 kg for a man, 8 to 12 kg for a woman. Buy the second bell before you buy a heavier one.

Grip

Two grips cover almost everything. For grinds you crush the handle. For ballistics you hold it loosely, in the fingers rather than the palm, and let the handle rotate as the bell travels. A death grip on a hundred snatches is how you tear a callus off.

Loose, in the fingers



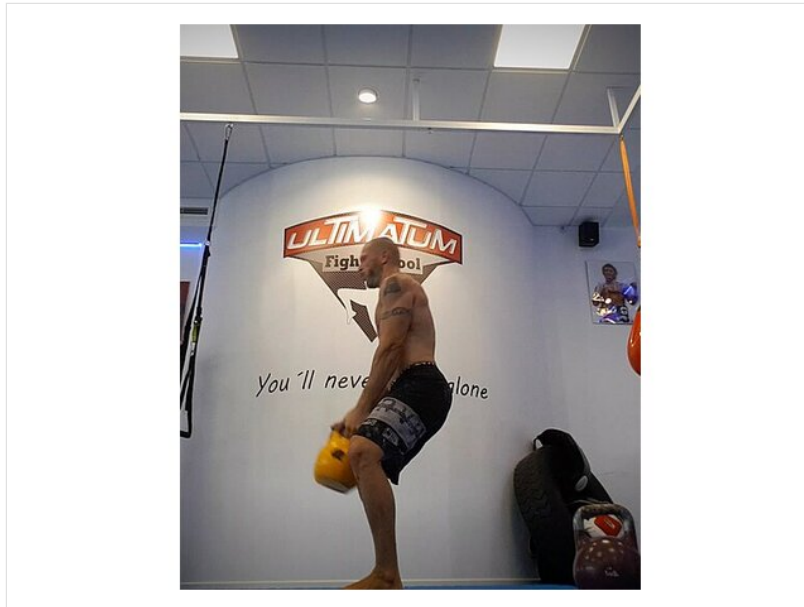
Crushed, for grinds



The hinge

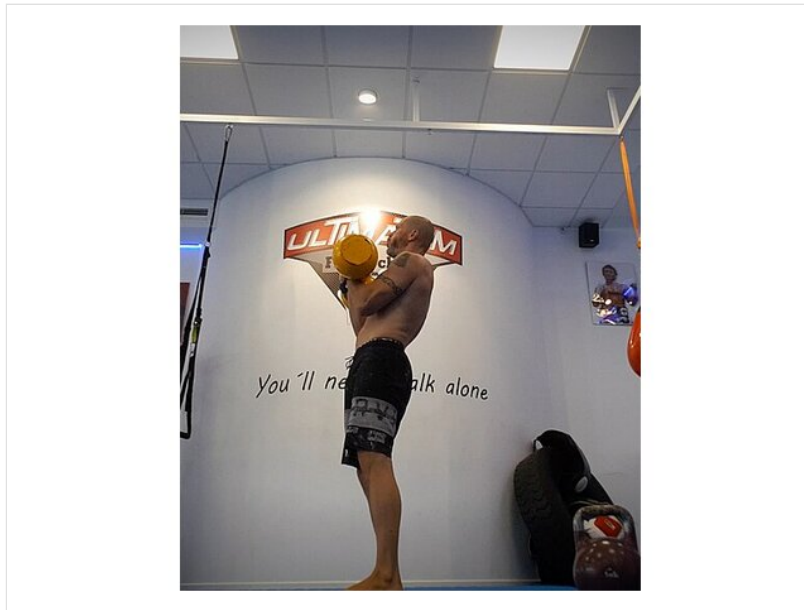
Push the hips back, let the torso tip forward to balance, keep the shins close to vertical and the spine neutral. It is not a squat. The knees bend a little because the hips travel back, not because you told them to. You should feel the hamstrings load.

Every ballistic lift in this guide, plus the deadlift, is a hinge.



The rack

Where the bell sits between a clean and a press. The handle rests on the heel of the hand, the forearm is vertical or close to it, the elbow is down and tucked into the ribs, and the bell rests on the forearm and chest. Done right it is a resting position and you can stand in it for a minute. Done wrong it is a shoulder held up by muscle, and it burns.



Breathing and bracing

Grinds get a braced trunk and slow controlled breath, never a held breath for a long set. Ballistics get a sharp exhale at the moment of effort. On the swing that is a hiss or a grunt as the hips snap. On the jerk it comes at the second dip. Long sets in kettlebell sport use their own rhythm, usually two breaths per rep, and that is a whole topic on its own.

S tier

Six lifts. If you only ever did these, you would still have a complete program.

Goblet squat

Hold one bell by the horns at chest height and squat. That is the whole exercise, and it is the fastest way to teach a person to squat properly that anyone has found. The bell in front acts as a counterweight, so the torso stays upright and the hips drop between the ankles instead of shooting back.

How to do it

1. Hold the bell by the horns, close to the sternum, elbows down.
2. Feet about shoulder width, toes slightly out.
3. Sit straight down. Push the knees out as you descend.
4. Go until the elbows pass inside the knees, deeper if your hips allow it.
5. Stand up by driving the floor away. Keep the chest tall.

Common mistakes. Letting the bell drift away from the chest, which turns it into a front raise. Heels lifting. Stopping at parallel out of habit when you could go deeper.

Use the prying version as a warm-up: sit in the bottom and gently push your knees out with your elbows for twenty or thirty seconds. It opens the hips for everything that follows.

Bottom position	Tutorial (click)
	

Press

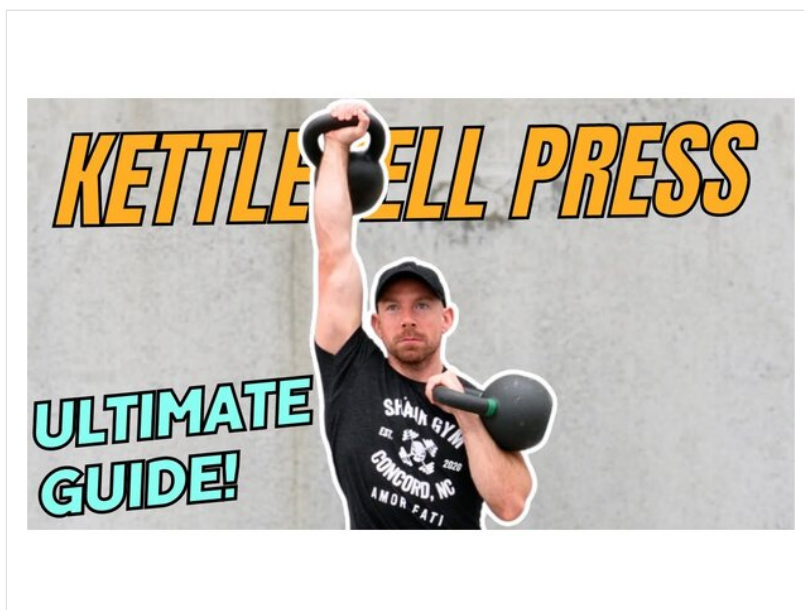
The strict overhead press from the rack. No leg drive, no lean, no bounce. It is the hardest kettlebell lift to cheat and the one that tells you the most about your actual upper body strength.

How to do it

1. Clean the bell to the rack. A bad rack makes a bad press.
2. Squeeze the handle, brace the trunk, glutes tight.
3. Pull the elbow down and back slightly to start, then drive up.
4. The bell travels close to the head. The hand rotates as it goes.
5. Lock out with the biceps near the ear and the shoulder packed.
6. Lower under control back to the rack. That is half the work.

Common mistakes. Pressing from a collapsed rack. Leaning away from the bell instead of standing tall. Rushing the negative. Losing the glutes and letting the lower back arch.

The press punishes a weak clean more than anything else in this guide. If you cannot rack it cleanly, fix that first.



Full snatch

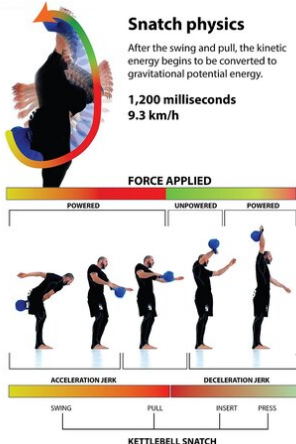
Ground to overhead in one unbroken movement. It is the most athletic thing you can do with a single bell, and it works the whole posterior chain, the shoulder, the grip and the lungs at the same time. Kettlebell sport calls the snatch the Tsar of the lifts and that is about right.

How to do it

1. Hike the bell back between the legs like a football snap.
2. Snap the hips through hard. The bell floats up on that momentum.
3. As it rises, pull the elbow high and back, close to the body.
4. Punch the hand up and through the window as the bell passes the head. This is the whole trick.
5. Lock out overhead with a straight arm, no crash on the forearm.
6. Drop it back into the backswing by leading with the elbow.

Common mistakes. Muscling it up with the arm instead of the hips. Letting the bell flip over and bang the wrist, which means you punched late. Death gripping the handle and shredding your hands.

The physics are worth understanding. The hips give the bell kinetic energy, and everything after that is you steering a moving object, not lifting it.

Snatch physics	Step by step (click)
 Snatch physics After the swing and pull, the kinetic energy begins to be converted to gravitational potential energy. 1,200 milliseconds 9.3 km/h FORCE APPLIED POWERED UNPOWERED POWERED ACCELERATION JERK DECELERATION JERK SWING PULL INSERT PRESS KETTLEBELL SNATCH	

Clean and jerk (long cycle)

Clean the bell or bells to the rack, jerk overhead, drop back to the rack, drop back down, repeat. Long cycle is the flagship event of kettlebell sport and it moves more total weight per minute than anything else in this guide. Ten minutes of long cycle with two 24 kg bells is a serious afternoon.

How to do it

1. Clean both bells to the rack from the backswing.
2. Settle. Breathe. The rack is a rest, so use it.
3. Dip at the knees, drive up, drop under, lock the bells overhead.
4. Fix the position for a beat with straight arms and locked knees.
5. Drop to the rack, absorb with the legs.
6. Drop to the backswing and clean again. The clean is what makes it the long cycle rather than the short.

Common mistakes. Rushing the rack and never recovering. Pressing the bells out instead of jerking them. Bending the arms in the clean and beating up your forearms.

Drive out of the dip	Tutorial (click)
	

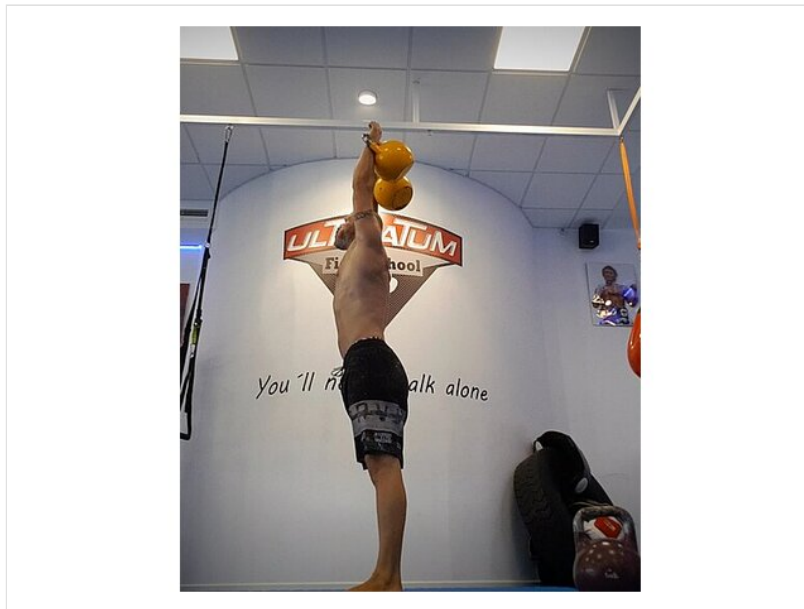
Jerk

The jerk on its own, without the clean between reps. From the rack, you dip, drive, drop under, and catch the bells overhead on locked arms. Roughly eighty percent of it is legs. The arms are there to stop the bells, not to raise them.

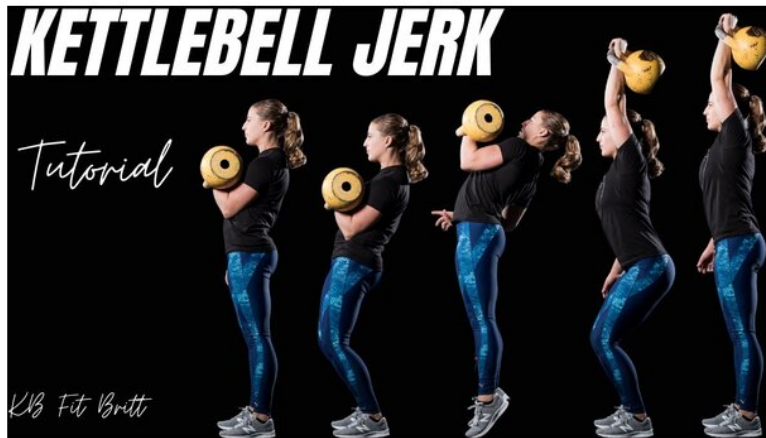
How to do it

1. Start in a solid rack, elbows on the hips if you can get them there.
2. First dip: a short, fast bend at the knees. Heels stay down.
3. Drive: extend hard and let the bells leave the rack.
4. Second dip: drop your body under the bells and catch them locked.
5. Stand up. Fix overhead until the bells stop moving.
6. Drop back to the rack and absorb.

Common mistakes. Dipping too deep, which turns it into a slow push press. Letting the elbows come off the body before the drive. Catching with soft elbows.



The two dips are what separates a jerk from a push press. Learn the timing with one light bell before you touch two heavy ones.



Pendulum swing

The kettlebell sport swing. The bell swings like a pendulum on a string, and your job is to guide it rather than fight it. Compared to the hardstyle swing it is lower, longer, and much cheaper in energy, which is exactly the point when you have ten minutes of snatches to get through.

How to do it

1. Start with the bell hanging, arm long and relaxed.
2. Let it fall into the backswing. Do not pull it back.
3. The arm stays connected to the body until the hips open.
4. Open the hips and let the bell float forward. Chest height is plenty, waist height is normal in a long set.
5. Follow it back down, absorb with the hips, repeat.

Common mistakes. Stopping the bell at the top like a hardstyle swing. Gripping too hard. Hinging on a schedule instead of waiting for the bell.

Loaded backswing	GS swing tutorial (click)
	

A tier

Good lifts, all of them. They sit here because each one is either a component of an S lift or a slightly narrower version of one.

Clean

Floor or backswing to the rack in one move. Almost nobody does cleans for their own sake, and yet the clean gates the press, the jerk, the thruster, the racked squat and the long cycle. Learn it properly and five other exercises get better.

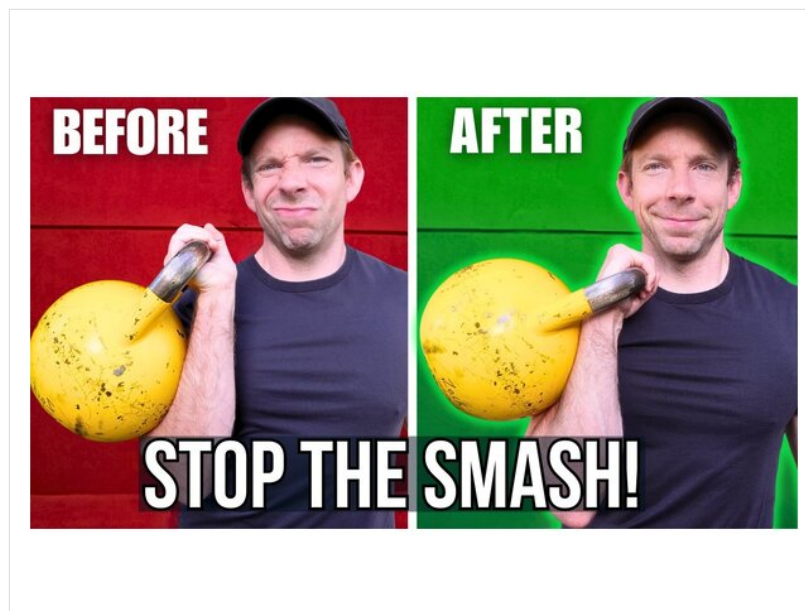
How to do it

1. Hike the bell back, same as a swing.
2. Snap the hips and keep the elbow close to your side.
3. As the bell rises, guide it in an arc toward the shoulder.
4. Open the hand and let the handle rotate around it. Insert the hand through the window.
5. The bell settles onto the forearm quietly. If it bangs, you were late.
6. Return by pushing the bell away and letting it fall into the backswing.

Common mistakes. Curling it up with the arm. Letting the bell travel too far out from the body, which is what causes the forearm smack. Keeping the hand closed so the bell has to flip over your fist.

Correct hand insert	What too far out looks like
	

If the forearm is bruised, the fix is almost always a lighter bell and a tighter arc, not a wrist guard.



Hardstyle swing

The two-hand swing to chest height, with everything braced and the hips snapping like a punch. It is the most efficient posterior chain exercise in the world per minute spent. Ten sets of ten with a heavy bell takes five minutes and leaves your glutes and hamstrings in no doubt about what happened.

How to do it

1. Bell a foot in front of you. Hinge, grab it, tilt the handle back.
2. Hike it hard between the legs, above the knees.
3. Snap the hips forward. Glutes hard, abs hard, quads hard.
4. The bell floats to chest height on its own. The arms do nothing.
5. Let it fall. Wait for it. Hinge at the last moment.

6. Sharp exhale on every snap.

Common mistakes. Squatting instead of hinging. Lifting the bell with the shoulders. Swinging above the head, which is a different exercise and a worse one for most people. Rounding the back in the backswing.

Top of the swing	The full tutorial (click)
	

Half snatch

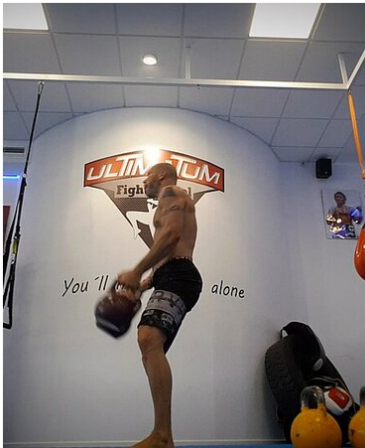
Snatch it up, then lower it to the rack instead of all the way down, and clean it back overhead from there. You get most of the pull of a full snatch with far less punishment on the hand, because the bell does not travel through the full drop every rep.

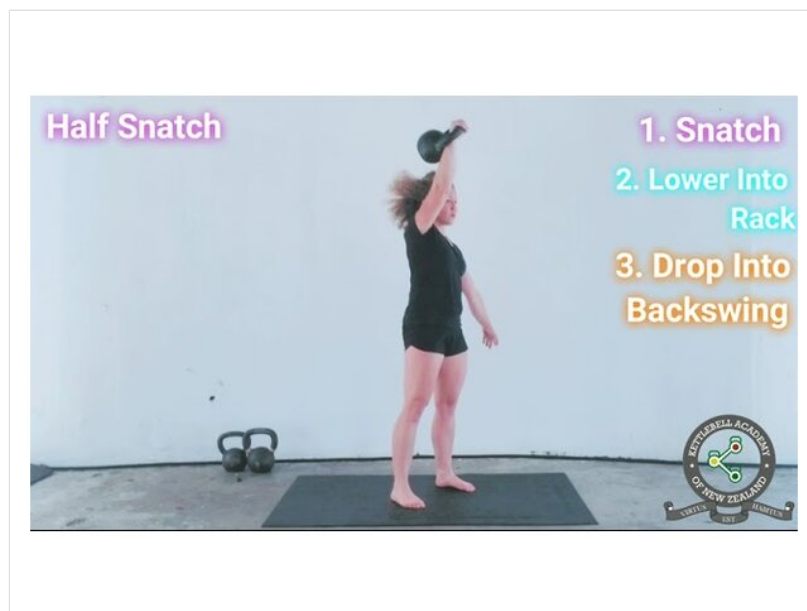
Useful as an accessory to the full snatch, and useful in its own right when your hands are torn up but you still want to train the pull.

How to do it

1. Snatch the bell overhead as normal.
2. Instead of dropping it to the backswing, lower it to the rack.
3. From the rack, drop into the backswing and pull again.
4. Alternate arms whenever you want. It is a very forgiving lift.

Common mistakes. Pressing out of the rack rather than pulling. Losing the vertical forearm on the way down.

Pull	Lockout
	



Deadlift

Bell on the floor between the feet, hinge, stand up with it. This is where a beginner should start, before any swing. It teaches the hinge under load at a speed where you can feel what your back is doing.

Two bells, or one heavy bell held with both hands, and the load gets respectable fast.

How to do it

1. Bell between the arches, feet hip width.
2. Push the hips back and reach down. Shins near vertical.
3. Flat back, chest proud, lats engaged so the shoulders do not round.
4. Push the floor away and stand tall. Squeeze the glutes at the top.
5. Hinge back down under control. Do not drop it.

Common mistakes. Squatting the weight up. Rounding the lower back at the bottom. Hyperextending at the top and leaning back.

The single-leg version is worth adding once the two-leg version is easy. It exposes hip stability problems you did not know you had.



B tier

Accessories. Add them when the S and A lifts are in place and you want to fill a gap.

Lunge

Split stance, back knee toward the floor, stand back up. Hold the bell in the goblet position to learn it, in the rack to make it harder and to load one side, or overhead if you want the shoulder involved too.

Reverse lunges are kinder to the knees than forward lunges and easier to balance. Start there.

How to do it

1. Hold the bell in the goblet or rack position.
2. Step one foot straight back.
3. Bend both knees. The back knee taps the floor lightly.
4. Push through the front heel to stand.
5. Keep the torso upright the whole time.

Common mistakes. Stepping back too short, which puts the front knee far past the toes. Leaning forward. Letting the front knee cave in.

The rack position version, one bell only, is the good one. The offset load makes the trunk work to stop you tipping.



Row

Hinge over, pull the bell to the hip. This is the only real pulling exercise on the list, and every other lift here is either a press or a hinge, so it earns its place by balancing the program. It ranks B rather than A because a pull-up bar or a barbell row does the same job with more load.

How to do it

1. Hinge to roughly forty-five degrees, one hand braced on a bench or your own thigh.
2. Let the bell hang directly under the shoulder.
3. Pull the elbow back toward the hip. Lead with the elbow.
4. Squeeze the shoulder blade at the top, hold for a beat.
5. Lower under control to a full stretch.

Common mistakes. Yanking with the biceps. Rotating the torso to help. Shrugging the shoulder toward the ear. Stopping the descent early and never letting the lat stretch.



C tier

Situational. Both are worth knowing and neither needs a regular slot.

Suitcase carry

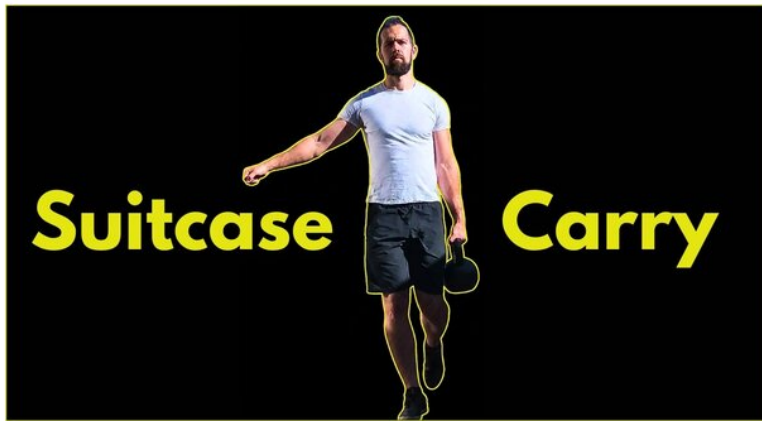
Pick up one bell, hold it at your side, walk. Your trunk spends the whole walk stopping you from bending sideways, and your grip spends it slowly failing. Simple, effective, and easy to bolt onto the end of a session.

How to do it

1. Deadlift one bell to the side of your body.
2. Stand tall. Ribs down, shoulders level, both of them.
3. Walk with short controlled steps for thirty to sixty seconds.
4. Swap hands and repeat. Never do only one side.

Common mistakes. Leaning away from the bell, which defeats the whole purpose. Hiking the loaded shoulder. Going so heavy the technique falls apart in five steps.

It ranks C because it is a finisher, not a training block. Very good at what it does and what it does is narrow.



Thruster

Front squat straight into an overhead press, with the leg drive carrying the bell up. Brutal conditioning. The problem is that it is a worse squat than the goblet squat and a worse press than the press, so the only reason to do it is the gasping, which is a real reason but a narrow one.

How to do it

1. Clean one or two bells to the rack.
2. Squat to depth, keeping the elbows tucked and the chest up.
3. Drive up out of the hole and let that momentum carry the bells.
4. Finish the movement with a press to lockout.
5. Lower to the rack and go straight into the next squat.

Common mistakes. Pausing between the squat and the press, which throws away the free momentum. Going too heavy and turning it into a slow grind. Losing the rack in the bottom of the squat.



D tier

Windmill

Bell locked out overhead, hips shifted to one side, torso rotating and hinging down until the free hand reaches the floor. The bell barely moves. You move underneath it.

It is genuinely good for hip and thoracic mobility and it does teach a strong overhead shoulder. It sits at D because the load will always be light relative to your real strength, and it takes a while to learn. As mobility work it is excellent. As strength work it is not.

How to do it

1. Press or clean and press the bell overhead. Eyes on it.
2. Turn the feet about forty-five degrees away from the loaded arm.
3. Push the hip under the bell out to the side.
4. Keep the loaded arm vertical and the loaded leg straight. Hinge down, front knee soft.
5. Reach the free hand toward the floor along the front leg.
6. Come back up by driving the hip forward.

Common mistakes. Bending the loaded arm. Turning it into a side bend instead of a hip shift and rotation. Losing sight of the bell.

Learn it with no weight, then with a shoe balanced on your fist, then with a light bell. Rushing this one is how shoulders get hurt.



E tier

Not bad exercises. Just not the ones to reach for first if your time is limited.

Bench press

Kettlebells make an awkward barbell. The offset load and the bell resting against the forearm mean the wrist has to work hard and the weight you can handle is well below what a barbell allows. If you have barbells, use them for this.

What kettlebells do add: the floor press variation, which limits the range of motion and is easy on cranky shoulders, and the crush grip press, where you squeeze a single bell between both palms and the chest works the whole time.

How to do it (floor press)

1. Lie down, one bell in each hand, elbows on the floor at 45 degrees.
2. Wrists straight, bells resting on the forearms.
3. Press up until the arms lock. Do not clash the bells.
4. Lower until the triceps touch the floor. Do not bounce.

Common mistakes. Bent wrists. Flaring the elbows to ninety degrees. Bouncing the elbows off the floor.



Around the world

Pass the bell around your waist from hand to hand, in a circle. Nice warm-up, decent coordination drill, mild core work. That is the whole story. It cannot be loaded meaningfully, so it earns its place at the start of a session and nowhere else.

Do not confuse it with the halo, which orbits the head and is a better shoulder mobility drill.

How to do it

1. Stand tall, feet about hip width, core braced.
2. Pass the bell around the waist, handing it off in front and behind.
3. Keep the hips still. The bell moves, you do not.
4. Ten each direction, slowly. Speed makes it easier, not harder.

Common mistakes. Swaying the hips to help the bell along. Going fast. Using a bell so heavy the handoff gets risky.



Atlas swing

Hold the bell by the horns and swing it in a figure of eight or a circular arc across the body, overhead and around, resisting the rotation the whole time. The obliques and the shoulders work hard for ten to twenty reps.

Fun, and better than its reputation for rotational core work. It sits in E for the same reason as around the world. You cannot load it, so it will never build much.

How to do it

1. Hold the bell by the horns with both hands.
2. Swing it up and across, letting it travel around the head and shoulders in a controlled arc.
3. Resist the pull. Keep the hips and ribs facing forward.
4. Ten to twenty reps, then reverse the direction.

Common mistakes. Letting the torso rotate with the bell. Going too heavy too early. Losing control behind the head.



Turkish get-up

Lie on your back with a bell locked out overhead, stand up without letting it move, then reverse the whole thing. Roughly seven steps each way, thirty seconds a rep, and every rep asks for total concentration.

Nobody argues it is a bad exercise. It builds a very stable shoulder and it exposes weak links you will not find anywhere else. The reason it lands at the bottom of a list ranked by return per minute is arithmetic: in the thirty seconds a get-up takes, you could do ten heavy swings. Many coaches weight it differently and put it near the top. Both positions are defensible.

How to do it

1. Roll to the bell, two hands on it, press it up. Eyes on it.
2. Same-side knee bent, foot flat. Free arm out at 45 degrees.
3. Roll up onto the free elbow.
4. Post up onto the free hand. Chest open.
5. Bridge the hips high.
6. Sweep the straight leg back under you into a half kneel.
7. Windshield wipe the back shin straight, then stand.
8. Reverse every step in order to get back down.

Common mistakes. Rushing. Taking your eyes off the bell in the early steps. Letting the elbow bend. Doing them heavy before the pattern is automatic.

Overhead lockout under load	Step by step (click)
	

Putting it together

The tiers tell you what to train. They do not tell you how to schedule it. Three templates that work:

Two bells, three days a week, general strength. Day one: press, goblet squat, row. Day two: swings and snatches for conditioning. Day three: clean and jerk ladders, lunges. Every session opens with the prying goblet squat and a few halos.

Minimum effective dose. Swings and get-ups, alternating, five days a week, thirty minutes total. This is Pavel Tsatsouline's Simple and Sinister and it works despite ignoring most of this list. Note that it leans hard on the get-up, which this guide ranks last, and it still works. Two lifts from [his twenty minute plan](#), the one-legged deadlift and the halo, are not in the nineteen at all. Rankings are a starting point, not a law.

Kettlebell sport. Long cycle and snatch, trained in timed sets that grow from two minutes toward ten. Everything else in this guide becomes accessory work. Buy competition bells before you commit to this.

Whatever you pick: press and pull in roughly equal amounts, hinge more than you squat, and add weight slowly. Kettlebells jump 4 kg at a time, which is a big jump on a press. Bridge the gaps with reps and sets rather than waiting to muscle the next bell up.

Video library

Every link verified in September 2026.

Exercise	Video	Source
Goblet squat	Kettlebell Goblet Squat: 1-Minute Complete Tutorial	Cat & Chau
Goblet squat	Heavy Kettlebell Goblet Squat	StrongFirst
Goblet squat	Kettlebell Prying Goblet Squat	StrongFirst
Press	Kettlebell Military Press (Ultimate Guide)	Zack Henderson
Press	Kettlebell Military Press Tutorial	Mike Stehle
Press	Kettlebell military press technique	Aleks Salkin
Full snatch	Kettlebell Snatch: Step-by-Step Tutorial	Cat & Chau
Full snatch	Proper Path of the Kettlebell Snatch	StrongFirst
Full snatch	Improve Your Kettlebell Snatch Lockout	StrongFirst
Full snatch	The Kettlebell Snatch: 4 easy steps	JTM_FIT
Long cycle	Kettlebell Long Cycle (Clean and Jerk) Tutorial	Pro Kettlebell
Long cycle	5 Long Cycle Tips to Make Lifting Easy	Rise Above Gym
Long cycle	Double Kettlebell Clean & Jerk	Aligned & Empowered
Jerk	Kettlebell Jerk Tutorial	Brittany van Schravendijk
Jerk	Two Arm Kettlebell Jerk Technique	Coach Gabe West
Jerk	Instructional: Two Kettlebell Clean and Jerk	moveSKILL
Pendulum swing	How to do a GS swing	Bells of Steel
Pendulum swing	Swing (Girevoy Sport) Kettlebell Exercise	MyMadMethods
Pendulum swing	Kettlebell Swing: Hardstyle vs Girevoy	Kat's Kettlebell Dojo
Clean	How to Kettlebell Clean (in 4 minutes)	Zack Henderson
Clean	Avoid Banging Wrist and Forearms	Funk Roberts
Clean	Clean Without Hurting Your Wrist/Forearm	Cavemantraining
Hardstyle swing	The Only Kettlebell Swing Tutorial You'll Ever Need	JTM_FIT
Half snatch	Half Snatch - Technique Demo	Kat's Kettlebell Dojo

Exercise	Video	Source
Half snatch	What is a Kettlebell Half Snatch?	Cavemantraining
Half snatch	Kettlebell Pentathlon Tutorial Part 4	notyourgymguy
Deadlift	How To Kettlebell Deadlift	Zack Henderson
Deadlift	Kettlebell Deadlift: Proper Form & Technique	NASM
Deadlift	Correct Form & Mistakes To Avoid	Myprotein
Lunge	Kettlebell Goblet Reverse Lunge	Onnit
Lunge	Kettlebell Front Rack Reverse Lunge	Movement As Medicine
Lunge	How to perform the kettlebell rack reverse lunge	Human Kinetics
Row	Single-Arm Bent Kettlebell Row	Onnit
Row	Single Arm Kettlebell Row	OPEX Fitness
Row	Single Arm KB Bent Over Row	Marcus Filly
Suitcase carry	Suitcase Carry with Kettlebell	Busy Man Kettlebell
Suitcase carry	Kettlebell Suitcase Carry	Rehab My Patient
Thruster	Kettlebell Thruster To Build Full-Body Strength	Pro Kettlebell
Thruster	Thruster Tutorial with Kettlebell	Amanda Bond Fitness
Windmill	Kettlebell Windmill Tutorial	Onnit
Windmill	How To Do The Kettlebell Windmill Like a Pro	Onnit / Shane Heins
Windmill	Standing Kettlebell Windmills Tutorial	Runna
Bench press	The Kettlebell Floor Press	Zack Henderson
Bench press	Kettlebell floor press / chest press	TheKB6
Bench press	Kettlebell Crush Grip Floor Press	Functional Bodybuilding
Around the world	Kettlebell Around the World Explained	Onnit / Shane Heins
Around the world	How to Perform a Kettlebell Around The World	Be a Game Character
Around the world	Kettlebell Halo Tutorial	Kettlebell Emma, the halo drill
Atlas swing	Atlas Swings And Explosive Core Exercises	VAHVA Fitness
Atlas swing	Atlas Swings with Kettlebell	Peter Marino
Atlas swing	Kettlebell Atlas Swing Exercise Demo	QuickCoach

Exercise	Video	Source
Turkish get-up	The Turkish Get Up (step by step)	Zack Henderson
Turkish get-up	The Turkish Get-Up: The Ultimate Tutorial	Cat & Chau
Turkish get-up	Turkish Get-Up: 2-Minute Complete Tutorial	Cat & Chau
Pavel method	The Only 3 Kettlebell Exercises You Need for Insane Strength at Any Age	Health Reveal
Pavel method	The Only 20 Minute Kettlebell Plan You Need After 50 (Pavel Method)	Health Reveal
Core Four	1 Kettlebell, 4 Moves, 3x per week	What Pertains to James

Image credits

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Four demonstration photos in the Pavel section, showing the one-legged deadlift, the towel swing, the halo and the seated press, were supplied by the author rather than drawn from Commons. So were the Core Four pictures of the thruster, row and swing. The Core Four push-up drawing is by Everkinetic, CC BY-SA 3.0, two frames from Commons stacked into one picture.

The remaining pictures are YouTube video thumbnails, shown as clickable links to the videos they belong to. Click any of them to open the tutorial.

All images are stored locally and standardized to 640 by 480 pixels on a white canvas, so the guide reads the same offline and the pictures line up evenly down the page.

Reference links

- [StrongFirst](#) - the hardstyle school, Pavel Tsatsouline's organization
- [Cavemantraining](#) - deep free written material, and the source of most photos here
- [Kettlebell swing on Wikipedia](#)
- [Kettlebell lifting on Wikipedia](#) - the sport, its history and rules
- [Wikimedia Commons: kettlebell exercises](#)
- [Kettlebells Workouts](#) - clear written teaching points per exercise
- [Kettlebell Windmill 101](#) - the best written breakdown of the windmill

- [Seven steps of the Turkish get-up](#) - the get-up, step by step in writing
 - [How to kettlebell snatch: the complete guide](#) - long written companion to the snatch video
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Written September 2026. Nothing here replaces coaching. If you are learning the snatch, the jerk or the get-up, one hour with a qualified instructor will save you months.